with the conspiracy. It was only when footage from this ‘interview’ was reproduced in a special Aaj Tak (‘100 Days After the Attack’) programme that it came to light that Afzal had actually explicitly exonerated Geelani. When S.A.R. Geelani’s defence lawyers called upon the Aaj Tak reporter who took that interview, Shams Tahir Khan, as a witness, it became clear from his deposition that journalists had in fact been instructed, indeed threatened, by the much decorated Delhi Police ‘Special Cell’ officer and ‘encounter’ specialist ACP Rajbir Singh that airing the latter part of Afzal’s ‘confession’ would invite dire consequences on any journalist present who chose to do so.

These developments did not deter Zee News, one of the most zealous extra-judicial prosecutors of the 13 December case, from producing an extensive ‘docudrama’ on 13 December which it aired on more than one occasion even as the trial progressed, including in the countdown to the final hearings in the special courts.

This television programme has an interesting and chequered history. Its premiere screening took place in the august presence of the then home minister and dead Pakistani identification expert, L.K. Advani. Advani praised the film as an excellent example of investigative journalism and in fact even compared it favourably to a subsequent Zee TV expose (on the attack on ‘Akshardham’ in Gujarat) saying that the former was much more meticulously and thoroughly produced. The film, which relayed and re-presented news, was itself news on the Zee News channel, and its making was featured as a lead story on the Zee News network. The film, with a stentorian commentary by the Bollywood ‘B’ movie star Raza Murad, featured a troupe of actors, enacting the ‘conspiracy’. The script of this television programme, as stated in a text insert at the beginning of the programme, is based on the charge sheet of the Delhi Police in the case. What is particularly interesting are the many parallels, both in plot, mise en scène and narrative detail, between the charge sheet, the Zee TV film and the Shahrukh Khan–Manisha Koirala-starring film by Mani Ratnam—*Dil Se*.[3] We see the same procedures —procurement and manufacture of identity cards, the reconnaissance of the landmarks of Lutyens’ Delhi on winter days, the listening to Hindi film music as terrorists work (on radio in the film, downloaded from computers in the TV programme), the hint of romance, the presence of a hard-line intellectual ideologue, the same locale—the alleyways of Old Delhi, around Karim’s—and the same method of masquerade as security ‘personnel’. There is an uncanny similarity between the plots, almost as if the ‘terrorists’, the police